

As we've mentioned in earlier books in this series, a person's online presence today is as crucial as his social identity offline. As more and more communication happens via e-mail, VoIP and teleconferencing, the strength of the Internet in the modern world can be figured from the fact that among the top five growing industries in the world, Internet or bandwidth providers stand at number four. This, however, does not include mobile connectivity.

The Internet today sits below the WWW and the TCP/IP protocols. Invented by Robert Kahn and Vinton Cerf in 1983, TCP/IP ensured a stable platform for the growth of Internet technology.

The Internet was born as the ARPANET in 1969—an experimental concept in which various computers were connected together to share resources and information. In the ARPANET, several nodes were connected to a host computer and a terminal server. There was, however, no certain protocol through which these nodes communicated with each other; each node communicated on the principle of token sharing, where each node had a specific time allocated to send and receive data.

Though it failed as an experiment, it laid the foundation for the modern Internet. Today, each computer that is connected to the Internet through the World Wide Web has its own, unique numerical identity and follows the TCP/IP protocol for sending and receiving information.

Various tools are required to optimally utilise the potential of the Internet. Browsers are at the top of this category. They provide the platform for accessing the Internet for a day-to-day average user. E-mail clients, Download Managers and Internet Chat Clients are some of the other essentials to get on the information superhighway. In this chapter, we take a look at some essential tools that enable you to do just that.